



MONTHLY UPDATE

Eswatini: monthly update, July 2026

Edition of 2026-08-13 · 26 systems and instruments tracked, 9 of them not held

Developments recorded from artefacts published between 2026-07-01 and 2026-08-09 — July 2026 carried forward to the date of issue, so the report holds the nightly catch to the day it was cut. Sections follow the status report.

Summary of the month

Eswatini's World Bank digital financing was [approved at more than E1.06bn on 19 July 2026](#) for a fibre backbone, connectivity for 1,031 public institutions and electronic identity by 2027. In the same weeks the data-protection authority [moved into sectoral rule-making](#), the National Data Governance Policy [reached validation](#), the regulator [proposed raising the minimum internet speed fivefold](#), and a parliamentary committee [put the price of a bank transaction on the record](#). The sponsoring ministry also [stated that data-protection enforcement is not its mandate](#) while announcing an instrument carrying data-protection duties.

Infrastructure

Connectivity

ESCCOM [proposed on 20 July 2026, in Notice 08/2026, raising the minimum internet speed from 2 Mbps to 10 Mbps](#), citing demand for high-bandwidth low-latency service. It is a proposal; the 2 Mbps standard stands.

At a workshop for ICT parastatal directors on 22 July, the Ministry of ICT [put mobile coverage at 95% and mobile-internet subscription at 57%](#), blaming data prices and paper-based public services, and set out a target of 859 schools and 134 health facilities to be connected. It named institutional leadership, not technology, as what will decide the outcome.

Free adjudication of consumer complaints against communications providers runs under the Eswatini Communications Commission Act 2013, with windows of one month for post and courier, three for broadcasting and six for telecommunications — a structural provision, not dated state.

Cybersecurity

On 30 July the SADC Committee of Central Bank Governors subcommittee on banking supervision, meeting at Ezulwini, [approved regional frameworks on cybersecurity, climate-related financial risk and cross-border crisis management](#). The Central Bank of Eswatini governor urged supervisors to extend oversight to cloud hosting providers, payment processors and AI used in credit scoring.

Digital public infrastructure

Digital Payments and Fintech

Three days after the FinScope survey launch, a Ministry of Finance portfolio committee [reported charges differing between institutions for equivalent services and higher than comparable banks in the sub-region](#), recommending the central bank benchmark them against SACU and Common Monetary Area banks within 30 days of adoption. The dated figure on the record is a withdrawal of E4,000 attracting E79 to E89 in fees; the ministry replied that the bank concerned had not raised charges but moved to real-time display of each fee.

Cross-border, an account published on 21 July established two things by implication. Eswatini's central bank governor [discussed leveraging Egyptian experience to accelerate PAPSS accession](#), which places Eswatini outside PAPSS as at that date. The same account reports low-value Common Monetary Area transactions migrating off domestic electronic-funds-transfer rails onto the TCIB scheme, with no timetable, volume, value or mandating instrument given.

Registries

On identity, a proposal to [require DNA testing before issuing birth certificates was costed at about E126m a year, roughly 46% of the Home Affairs budget](#) — about E4,300 per test across about 29,400 births.

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The same Digital Eswatini connectivity target names 38 tinkhundla centres to be connected, none reported connected as at 22 July ([source](#)).

National statistics

The central bank [launched the FinScope Eswatini 2026 Consumer Survey on 24 July](#) with ESEPARC, the Central Statistical Office and FinMark Trust. Its governor said the 87% access rate recorded in 2018 measured access rather than use, and that the 2026 round will cover access, usage and quality — the first measurement since the Consumer Credit Act, the payment switch and the FinTech Strategy changed the stack. No fieldwork dates, sample size or publication date were given.

Governance and regulation

Legislation and regulation

In the same 4 August answer, the ICT ministry said it had completed the Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026, introducing a registration requirement for online publishers bound to accuracy, privacy protection, child safeguarding and the responsible use of AI. Neither the text nor a commencement date is public.

Strategies, plans and policies

The National Data Governance Policy [was validated on 27 July 2026](#) by stakeholders from government, business, civil society, academia and development partners, with a stated cycle of 2027 to 2031 — a policy dated to begin the year after it was drafted. Support runs through the Team Europe Data Governance in Africa initiative, the same channel behind the April 2026 workshop. The text is not published and no adoption date is given.

Standards

Asked on 4 August how online publications comply with the data-protection law, the ICT ministry [answered that implementation, enforcement and oversight do not fall within its direct mandate](#) but are vested in ESCCOM.

Data protection

The next day ESCCOM, as the data protection authority, [began validating draft advisory guidelines on the lawful processing of personal health data](#) at Ezulwini, with the health ministry, providers, insurers, pharmacies and medical aid schemes. They will be published as a regulatory instrument under the Data Protection Act 2022, covering collection, retention, sharing, breach notification, cloud services and patient rights. The commission disclosed that it has concluded a complaint over a practitioner's unlawful disclosure of a patient's information.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

AI

Eswatini's second instrument to carry AI rules arrived in the month, and like the first it is not an AI instrument: the [Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026 bind registered publishers to the responsible use of AI](#), enforced through the registration requirement they create. There is still no national AI strategy or statute behind either.

On 6 July the prime minister told the [Global Dialogue on AI Governance in Geneva that small and developing nations should not become mere consumers of technologies developed elsewhere](#), an address the National 4IR Strategy frames.

[A regional health body and a private firm signed a memorandum in Eswatini on 4 August to scale AI-enabled health solutions](#), naming no system, no data-sharing terms and no money.

ICT Industry

Domestically, [Letshego Eswatini set out plans to expand digital banking to the unbanked](#) following the grant of a provisional banking licence.

Innovation ecosystem

[Digital transformation was named a priority of the Eswatini-Taiwan relationship](#) at a leaders' meeting in Taipei, with no instrument, figure or implementing agency named; the meeting's own date is not established.

US / hyperscaler activities

(narrative not yet written)

Gulf/UAE activities

On 22 July the [She Powers Africa Digital Academy launched virtually](#) under an Eswatini-UAE memorandum signed at the 2025 UN General Assembly. Delivery is by the UAE's General Women's Union with its telecommunications regulator, covering AI, cybersecurity, data science and software development. The first cohort is 50 women from government institutions.

Inclusion and capacity

Digital divides

On 6 August the [Macetjeni Integrated Business, Employment and Innovation Hub was launched in the Lubombo Region](#), the second after Pigg's Peak, established by the Small Enterprises Development Company with ESCCOM and UNDP. A third hub is in preparation for Shiselweni, with no start date, provider or cohort size given.

Training and skills

At the Macetjeni handover the ICT ministry's principal secretary said [AI, robotics, coding and cybersecurity courses would follow](#) at the innovation hubs.

Finance

New investments

The month's largest item is the financing: the ICT ministry's first-quarter performance report established that Eswatini has [secured approval for more than E1.06bn in World Bank financing for the Digital Eswatini Project](#), converted in the source at E16.37 to the dollar on 19 July 2026.

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